

Digital Twins for Predictive Maintenance in Automotive Aftersales

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Abstract—This paper examines the effect of digital-twin-based predictive maintenance on the automotive aftersales domain, focusing on the German passenger-car market. Combining a structured literature review with a model-based gap analysis, we compare an interval-based current state against a digital-twin-enabled target state along the full customer journey, then quantify the business potential using an explicit, transparent assumption framework anchored to published German market data. The results show that proactive, data-driven service recommendations raise the repair capture rate from 40 to 70 percent, increasing wear-part gross profit by approximately 55 EUR per vehicle per year and 276,000 EUR annually across a 5,000-vehicle fleet. Customer touchpoints grow from 1.5 to roughly 2.5 per year, each representing an additional advisory and upselling opportunity. The findings establish a transparent, contestable model of the potential that dealerships and OEMs can use to evaluate and plan the integration of digital-twin-based predictive maintenance into their aftersales operations.

Index Terms—Digital Twin, Predictive Maintenance, Connected Vehicle, Machine Learning, Automotive Aftersales, Condition Monitoring

I. INTRODUCTION

Today’s vehicles are connected by default and continuously transmit operating data [1], [2], so the information needed to judge their technical condition largely exists. Yet aftersales remains reactive: even well-connected vehicles are serviced on fixed time or mileage intervals rather than on the actual condition of their components [3]. Wear parts—brake pads and discs, tyres, ignition parts, or wipers—are replaced only once a fault becomes visible, so customers run them to failure and the unplanned repair often goes to a cheaper third-party garage [4]. For the dealership, which owns the customer relationship, this means losing both the repair and one of only a few yearly customer contacts—each also a chance to advise, retain, and sell [5], [6].

Digital-twin-based predictive maintenance (PdM) can turn this data into foresight. A digital twin (DT) maintains a synchronised virtual representation of the vehicle [7], against which machine-learning models forecast the remaining useful life of components and recommend replacement before failure—keeping the customer at the dealership and enabling transparent, targeted upselling. While the building blocks of DT-based PdM are well studied in industrial and aerospace settings [8], [9], their integration into automotive aftersales remains underexplored.

This paper therefore asks: *what effect does the proactive use of digital twins and predictive maintenance have on the automotive aftersales domain?* Focusing on the German market and working with explicitly stated assumptions, we (i) establish a quantitative business case for DT/PdM integration in franchised dealerships using a transparent, assumption-driven model anchored to published German market data, (ii) compare the predictive target state with the interval-based current state along the full customer journey to identify where reactive servicing causes value leakage, and (iii) derive actionable recommendations for dealerships and OEMs.

II. RELATED WORK AND THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

A. Digital Twins

The concept of the digital twin was first introduced by Grieves [7] in a white paper on manufacturing excellence, where it described a virtual replica of a physical product maintained in synchrony with its real-world counterpart throughout the entire asset lifecycle. Since then, the concept has expanded into aerospace, energy, and automotive domains [8], [10].

In the automotive domain, this general architecture maps directly onto the connected vehicle. The physical entity is the vehicle itself, equipped with on-board sensors and an On-Board Diagnostic (OBD) interface. The virtual representation is a cloud-hosted model mirroring component states, degradation histories, and operating conditions. The synchronising link is the over-the-air (OTA) telematics connection, which transmits telemetry to the cloud and returns configuration updates to the vehicle [1], [2]. Figure 1 illustrates this three-layer architecture. Architecturally, automotive digital twins are typically realised as modular, microservice-based platforms. A data ingestion layer normalises heterogeneous sensor streams—including vibration, temperature, voltage, and Controller Area Network (CAN)-bus signals—before forwarding them to a model layer that maintains the current state of each monitored component [11], [12]. The outputs are then exposed to external consumers such as Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) backends or workshop notification services [1], [9], forming the basis for predictive maintenance strategies.

B. Vehicle Maintenance Strategies

Vehicle maintenance strategies form a maturity hierarchy: reactive maintenance repairs only after failure [9]; preventive

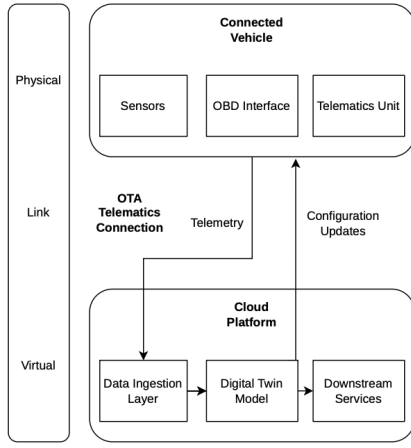


Fig. 1. Three-layer architecture of an automotive digital twin.

maintenance schedules service at fixed mileage or time intervals, leading to either premature replacement or undetected wear [9], [11]; condition-based maintenance (CBM) couples the service decision to sensor thresholds [11]; and PdM extends CBM by forecasting the future evolution of degradation, estimating the remaining time or distance until end-of-life is reached [9], [13].

PdM at this scale is not a stand-alone technique but a service layer built on a DT of the vehicle. As Lopes et al. [1] and Hadraoui et al. [11] describe, the DT supplies the synchronised virtual representation against which sensor streams are interpreted, anomalies detected, and remaining-useful-life estimates computed. In current automotive DT architectures, predictive analytics is therefore typically positioned as a dedicated microservice within the DT's analytics core [1], [9], [12].

C. Machine Learning in PdM

Three problem classes structure machine-learning (ML)-based PdM. Classification assigns sensor patterns to discrete fault categories using Support Vector Machines, Random Forests, or Convolutional Neural Networks on time-frequency representations of vibration signals [9], [13]. Regression targets Remaining Useful Life (RUL) estimation, dominated by Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks for their ability to model long-range temporal dependencies in degradation signals [9], [12]. Anomaly detection operates without explicit labels, learning nominal behaviour and flagging deviations as failure precursors [9], [12]. In the aftersales context, RUL regression is the primary mechanism behind proactive service recommendations; anomaly detection serves as an early-warning layer for components without established wear curves, where labelled failure data is absent.

D. Automotive Aftersales

Aftersales encompasses post-purchase activities that help customers access supplier services and resolve product issues through continuous maintenance and upkeep [14]. In

the automotive context, it functions as a dedicated business module bundling maintenance, repair, and warranty offerings to maximise product use throughout the asset lifecycle while meeting financial and customer-performance targets [6], [15]. Building post-sales relationships strengthens customer loyalty, yields actionable insights, and creates upselling and cross-selling opportunities [16], making the automotive aftersales market increasingly attractive as demand for higher-quality service expands [6].

Historically, once the warranty expires, customer engagement with the dealership tends to decline. Within the automotive industry, aftersales services represent a particularly significant source of revenue, with profit margins considerably exceeding those generated through vehicle sales [17]. From an economic standpoint, the aftersales service market has been identified as substantially larger than the primary product sales market across various industries [10], [18], [19]. Retaining these customers requires better information systems and service processes [14].

Proactive aftersales improves customer satisfaction and retention by resolving issues before customers encounter them, enabling more productive service interactions [5]. This requires tailoring services to customer needs through tight integration of operational and informational data [14]. ML and DT-based approaches enable predictive interventions and better asset lifecycle optimisation, delivering cost reduction, improved customer satisfaction, and extended asset lifetimes [20].

E. Synthesis and Research Gap

The preceding subsections establish three building blocks: the DT as a synchronised vehicle model, PdM as a prognostic analytics layer built on top of it, and aftersales as the customer-facing business context in which service decisions are communicated and acted upon. Together, they form a potential end-to-end system in which the DT continuously feeds component-state data to ML-based PdM models, whose forecasts are surfaced through aftersales processes to enable proactive service appointments and retain customers at the dealership.

While the referenced contributions establish the technical foundations of DT-based PdM, existing work concentrates either on algorithmic aspects in isolation [9], [13] or on industrial applications [8]. The integration of DT-based PdM into automotive aftersales business models, particularly regarding its implications for customer interaction, remains underexplored. The present work addresses this gap.

III. METHODOLOGY

This paper combines a structured literature review with a model-based gap analysis to answer the research question. The two steps are designed to complement each other: the review establishes what is technically possible and identifies where existing work stops short; the gap analysis then quantifies the business consequences of that shortfall for a concrete reference case.

a) *Literature review.*: The theoretical grounding rests on a targeted review of recent academic literature on DT, PdM, and automotive aftersales. Sources were identified through database searches on IEEE Xplore, Scopus, and Google Scholar using term clusters centred on *digital twin*, *predictive maintenance*, *automotive*, and *aftersales*, supplemented by reference tracing from key contributions. Selection prioritised peer-reviewed work with quantitative or architectural results published from 2015 onward, reflecting the period in which automotive DT architectures reached practical maturity [1]; foundational conceptual works predating this window were included where they introduced concepts still in active use [7]. The resulting synthesis is presented in Section II.

b) *Gap analysis.*: The gap analysis proceeds in two stages. First, a lifecycle comparison (Section IV-A) contrasts the interval-based current state of aftersales against a DT/PdM-enabled target state along the customer journey, identifying the structural points at which reactive servicing causes value leakage. Second, a quantitative potential assessment translates the identified gap into economic KPIs using an explicit assumption framework. Because no public, in-service failure dataset exists for the German passenger-car market at the resolution required [9], the assessment is model-based: assumptions are anchored to published statistics where available and stated as set values otherwise, making the model transparent and contestable. A single economic lever—the repair capture rate c , the share of addressable wear-part work retained at the franchised dealership—is used to quantify the gap. The target capture rate is derived analytically from the mechanism assumptions rather than assumed directly, ensuring internal consistency. A one-way sensitivity analysis over c confirms that the economic case holds across a plausible parameter band [21].

IV. GAP ANALYSIS

A. Current- and Target-State Lifecycle Comparison

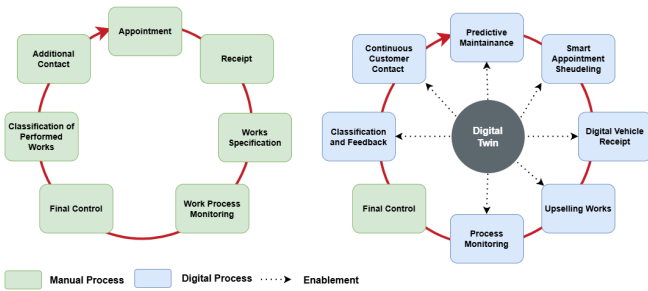


Fig. 2. Aftersales lifecycle: current interval-based state (left) versus DT/PdM-enabled target state (right).

The target of this comparison is to expose the structural differences between two states of the aftersales lifecycle—one without and one with integration of digital-twin-based predictive maintenance—along the full customer journey from vehicle operation through service execution to post-repair

follow-up. The comparison reveals at which points in the lifecycle reactive servicing causes value leakage and where a predictive architecture would redirect that value back to the franchised dealership.

a) *Current state.*: In the interval-based current state, the customer journey is driven by fixed manufacturer schedules and visible failure signals. The vehicle operates without continuous component-state monitoring; no wear forecast is computed during normal driving. Service appointments are initiated either by a time- or mileage-triggered reminder displayed on the instrument cluster, or by an acute fault manifesting as a warning lamp or perceptible degradation in braking or ride performance. Both triggers are late-stage events: the mileage interval is set conservatively to cover the worst-case fleet population, so most vehicles reach the workshop with substantial remaining part life; the fault-driven trigger often arrives after the wear limit has already been exceeded [9]. Because no proactive outreach precedes the fault, the customer exercises free choice of workshop at the moment of highest urgency, and the majority of these unplanned repairs are captured by independent third-party garages [22], [23]. The dealership's contact with the customer is therefore reduced to the statutory inspection cycle, limiting both retention and upselling opportunity.

b) *Target state.*: In the DT/PdM-enabled target state, the vehicle's digital twin continuously aggregates sensor streams, OBD signals, and OTA telemetry to maintain an up-to-date virtual representation of each monitored component [1]. Machine-learning models operating on this virtual representation compute remaining-useful-life estimates for wear parts such as brake pads and discs, tyres, and ignition components [12], [13]. When the forecast horizon falls below a configurable threshold, the system generates a proactive service recommendation communicated to the customer through the OEM's connected-car interface or the dealership's CRM before any visible fault has occurred [5], [20]. The appointment is scheduled at the customer's convenience, the required parts are pre-ordered, and the workshop interaction is transformed from an unplanned, fault-driven event into a planned, evidence-based service visit. Post-service, the digital twin resets the component baseline and resumes monitoring, closing the lifecycle loop. The dealership thereby intercepts wear-part replacements that would otherwise be lost to the independent aftermarket and gains structured contact points along the customer journey that the current state does not provide.

B. Assumption Framework

Because public, in-service failure datasets representative of this setting are largely absent [9], the comparison is built on an explicit assumption framework rather than on a proprietary dataset. Assumptions are divided into *context* assumptions, which fix the reference case (Table I), *wear-part* assumptions, which size the addressable work (Table II), and *mechanism* assumptions, which govern the transition from the current to

the target state (Table III). Each is anchored to a published figure where one exists and flagged as a set value otherwise.

TABLE I
CONTEXT ASSUMPTIONS.

ID	Assumption	Value
A1	Reference vehicle	Mid-segment ICE passenger car, German market
A2	Annual mileage	12,300 km/yr [24]
A3	First-owner horizon	8 years [23]
A4	Workshop visits	1.5/yr [22]
A5	Considered wear parts	Brake pads/discs, tyres, wipers, 12 V battery, spark plugs
A6	Service gross margin	50 % (range 45–55 % [23])
A7	Franchised share	43 % [22]

The wear parts in A5 are deliberately limited to components whose wear is gradual, usage-driven and not readily perceived by the driver — the class for which a forecast adds the most decision value and which dominates both between-interval failures and the most common defect categories in the mandatory German vehicle safety inspection (Hauptuntersuchung, HU: brakes, lighting, tyres) [25]. Prescriptive maintenance and powertrain overhauls are out of scope. Typical replacement intervals and representative German market prices (parts plus labour, incl. VAT) are given in Table II; prices are published market ranges [26] and major automotive service providers used at their midpoints. Where a published range exists, a representative value within it is used; individual prices may fall toward either end, but the sensitivity analysis brackets this residual uncertainty.

TABLE II
WEAR-PART ASSUMPTIONS (MIDPOINTS). PRICES COVER PARTS PLUS LABOUR, INCL. VAT; MIDPOINTS OF PUBLISHED GERMAN MARKET RANGES [26].

Part (A5)	Interval	Events/yr (at A2)	Price
Brake pads (per axle)	40,000 km	0.31	€ 250
Brake discs (+pads, front)	120,000 km	0.10	€ 450
Tyres (set of 4)	45,000 km	0.27	€ 600
Wiper blades (pair)	1 year	1.00	€ 25
12 V battery (fitted)	6 years	0.17	€ 150
Spark plugs (set)	60,000 km	0.21	€ 150

For the mechanism, we model a single lever: the *repair capture rate* c , the share of addressable wear-part work performed at the franchised dealership rather than lost to an independent garage. Its complement $(1 - c)$ is the leakage. The current capture rate, the forecast accuracy, and the proactive-offer conversion are stated in Table III; the target capture rate is not assumed independently but derived from them.

The target capture rate is derived, not assumed: of the leaked share $(1 - c_{\text{cur}})$, the fraction that PdM forecasts (a) and that converts on a proactive offer (k) is recaptured. We set $a=1$ because customers cannot distinguish a true-positive forecast from a false-positive recommendation—every offer is

evaluated and accepted or declined at rate $a \cdot k$ regardless of whether the underlying wear has fully materialised:

$$\begin{aligned}
 c_{\text{tgt}} &= c_{\text{cur}} + (1 - c_{\text{cur}}) \cdot a \cdot k \\
 &= 0.40 + 0.60 \cdot 1.0 \cdot 0.50 \\
 &= 0.40 + 0.30 = 0.70.
 \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

TABLE III
MECHANISM ASSUMPTIONS (CURRENT STATE → TARGET STATE).

ID	Assumption (Symbol)	Value	Basis
A8	Current capture rate (c_{cur})	0.40	<43 % share [22]
A9	PdM forecast accuracy (a)	0.90	89–92 % [9]; $a=1$ in model
A10	Proactive-offer conversion (k)	0.50	Conserv. est. [5], [27]
—	Target capture rate (c_{tgt} , deriv.)	0.70	$c_{\text{cur}} + (1 - c_{\text{cur}}) \cdot a \cdot k$, $a=1$

This construction keeps the estimate conservative and never approaches full capture. The conversion rate ($k = 0.50$, A10) is a conservative estimate: proactive, personalised maintenance contact from the customer’s own dealership is consistent with findings that proactive contact aids uptake and loyalty [5], [27], yet price competition from independent garages and customer inertia toward switching service providers prevent full conversion, making 0.50 a deliberate floor rather than a central estimate.

C. Potential Assessment

The calculation proceeds in three steps: the addressable wear-part value per vehicle, the captured value under each state, and the resulting KPIs at vehicle, fleet and lifecycle level.

Step 1 — Addressable wear-part value: For each part i , the expected annual revenue is its replacement rate λ_i [yr^{-1}] multiplied by its unit price p_i ; both are from Table II, with λ_i computed on unrounded mileage (A2). Summing across A5 yields the annual addressable wear-part revenue per vehicle:

$$\begin{aligned}
 V_{\text{wear}} &= \sum_i \lambda_i \cdot p_i \\
 &= 76.9 + 46.1 + 164.0 + 25.0 + 25.0 + 30.7 \\
 &\approx \text{€ } 368 \text{ per vehicle per year.}
 \end{aligned}$$

Step 2 — Captured value: Applying the capture rates from Table III:

$$\text{Captured}_{\text{cur}} = c_{\text{cur}} \cdot V_{\text{wear}} = 0.40 \cdot 368 \approx \text{€ } 147 \text{ /veh/yr,} \tag{2}$$

$$\text{Captured}_{\text{tgt}} = c_{\text{tgt}} \cdot V_{\text{wear}} = 0.70 \cdot 368 \approx \text{€ } 258 \text{ /veh/yr.} \tag{3}$$

Applying the service gross margin (A6) gives the captured gross profit.

TABLE IV
CURRENT-STATE / TARGET-STATE KPI COMPARISON. DELTA FIGURES
COMPUTED DIRECTLY ON UNROUNDED INTERMEDIATE VALUES; CURRENT
AND TARGET CELLS ROUNDED INDEPENDENTLY.

KPI	Current	Target	Δ
Repair capture rate	40 %	70 %	+30 pp
Wear-part revenue (/veh/yr)	€ 147	€ 258	+€ 110
Gross profit (/veh/yr)	€ 74	€ 129	+€ 55
Fleet GP, 5,000 veh (/yr)	€ 368k	€ 644k	+€ 276k
Customer touchpoints (/yr)	1.5	~2.5	+1.0
First-pass inspection rate	baseline	improved	qual.
Lifecycle retention [23]	~25 %	sustained	qual.

Step 3 — KPIs: Table IV summarises the comparison. Revenue and gross-profit figures are per vehicle per year; the fleet column scales the gross-profit delta linearly to a representative franchised group of 5,000 active customer vehicles.

The proactive touchpoint count rises because each high-value forecast event (the wear parts in Table II excluding the wiper case, ≈ 1.0 events/yr) triggers an outreach contact that did not exist in the interval-based current state, roughly doubling the meaningful contact frequency from 1.5 to about 2.5 per year, assuming forecast contacts fall outside scheduled service visits; overlap would reduce the net gain modestly. Each additional contact is also an advisory and upselling opportunity; the parts targeted—brakes and tyres above all—are among the most common defect categories in the German mandatory vehicle safety inspection (HU) [25], so proactive replacement directly improves the customer’s first-pass inspection rate, a tangible and communicable benefit.

Sensitivity: The result depends most on the target capture rate. Varying c_{tgt} across a plausible band while holding V_{wear} and the 50 % margin fixed gives a per-vehicle gross-profit delta of:

$$\begin{aligned}
 c_{tgt} = 0.50 &\rightarrow \Delta \text{ gross profit} \approx \text{€ } 18 \text{ /veh/yr,} \\
 c_{tgt} = 0.60 &\rightarrow \Delta \text{ gross profit} \approx \text{€ } 37 \text{ /veh/yr,} \\
 c_{tgt} = 0.70 &\rightarrow \Delta \text{ gross profit} \approx \text{€ } 55 \text{ /veh/yr,} \\
 c_{tgt} = 0.80 &\rightarrow \Delta \text{ gross profit} \approx \text{€ } 74 \text{ /veh/yr.}
 \end{aligned}$$

Even at the conservative end the dealership captures additional gross profit on the order of tens of euros per vehicle per year, scaling to a six-figure annual sum across a mid-size fleet—before accounting for the compounding retention effect, namely that dealer-serviced customers are substantially more likely to purchase their next vehicle from the same dealership [28] (US data). The economic case is therefore robust to the assumptions rather than an artefact of any single optimistic value.

D. Limitations

The analysis is intentionally assumption-driven and carries corresponding limitations. First, the figures are illustrative: V_{wear} , the capture rates and the conversion factor are anchored to published market and accuracy data but are not fitted to an operational dataset, and no prototype was built;

the contribution is a transparent model of the potential, not a measured outcome. Second, the PdM forecast accuracy (A9, 90 %) is reported for transparency but does not enter the capture-rate formula. Because a proactive service recommendation looks identical to the customer whether the underlying forecast is correct or slightly premature, both true-positive and false-positive predictions generate the same type of offer, accepted or declined at rate k . Accuracy will improve continuously as in-service data accumulates [9], but the model outcome does not depend on reaching any particular accuracy threshold. Third, and most consequential for practice, the target state presumes the dealership can actually obtain the vehicle’s telemetry. Under the EU Data Act (applicable from 12 September 2025) the user is the vehicle owner or driver, who may authorise a third party such as the dealership to receive in-vehicle data on fair, reasonable and non-discriminatory terms, while the OEM remains the data holder; where the data is personal, the GDPR additionally requires a lawful basis [29]. Access is thus contingent on customer consent, OEM provisioning in a usable format, and business-to-business (B2B) compensation — a non-technical adoption barrier that the model does not price in. Finally, two scope caveats apply: tyres, though included as a wear part, are often served by specialist channels and may leak independently of the dealership’s PdM capability; the shift to BEVs will erode ICE-specific wear-part volume and shift the addressable basket toward brakes, tyres, and the high-voltage battery.

V. DISCUSSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

VI. CONCLUSION & FUTURE WORK

A. Conclusion

This paper examined the effect of digital-twin-based predictive maintenance on automotive aftersales, focusing on the German passenger-car market. A lifecycle comparison showed that the transition from interval-based servicing to a DT/PdM-enabled target state redirects wear-part work from the independent aftermarket back to the franchised dealership by replacing reactive, fault-driven appointments with proactive, evidence-based service recommendations. A quantitative potential assessment, anchored to published German market data, translated this shift into concrete KPIs: under a conservative conversion assumption ($k = 0.50$), the repair capture rate rises from 40 % to 70 %, increasing gross profit by approximately € 55 per vehicle per year and € 276k annually across a 5 000-vehicle fleet. Customer touchpoints grow from 1.5 to roughly 2.5 per year, each an additional advisory and upselling opportunity. The sensitivity analysis confirmed the economic case is robust across the full plausible parameter range. The dominant adoption barrier is non-technical: access to in-vehicle telemetry requires customer consent and OEM provisioning under the EU Data Act and GDPR, a hurdle any real-world deployment must resolve.

B. Future Work

Three directions stand out for future research. First, the assumption framework should be validated against an oper-

ational DT deployment, replacing modelled KPIs with measured outcomes and calibrating the conversion rate k under real customer-behaviour conditions. Second, the data-access challenge warrants dedicated study: viable consent architectures and OEM-dealer data-sharing agreements under the EU Data Act need to be developed and their effect on customer opt-in quantified. Third, the framework should be extended to battery electric vehicles, where the high-voltage battery's state of health becomes the dominant prognostic target and the addressable wear-part basket shifts away from ICE-specific components such as spark plugs.

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VERWENDUNG GENERATIVER KI-SYSTEME

Bei der Erstellung der eingereichten Arbeit haben wir die nachfolgend aufgeführten auf künstlicher Intelligenz (KI) basierten Systeme benutzt:

1) Claude (Anthropic)

Wir erklären, dass wir

- uns aktiv über die Leistungsfähigkeit und Beschränkungen der oben genannten KI-Systeme informiert haben,
- die aus den oben angegebenen KI-Systemen direkt oder sinngemäß übernommenen Passagen gekennzeichnet haben,
- überprüft haben, dass die mithilfe der oben genannten KI-Systeme generierten und von uns übernommenen Inhalte faktisch richtig sind,
- uns bewusst sind, dass wir als Autorinnen bzw. Autoren dieser Arbeit die Verantwortung für die in ihr gemachten Angaben und Aussagen tragen.

Die oben genannten KI-Systeme haben wir wie im Folgenden dargestellt eingesetzt:

Tabelle I. Einsatz von KI-Systemen

Arbeitsschritt	Eingesetzte(s) KI-System(e)	Beschreibung der Verwendungsweise
Formatierung und Satz	Claude (Anthropic)	Umwandlung von Fließtext in $\text{\LaTeX}$ (Tabellen, Formeln, Literaturverzeichnis)
Verifikation der Berechnungen	Claude (Anthropic)	Prüfung der Zwischenrechnungen (V_{wear} , Capture-Raten) auf Konsistenz
Sprachliche Überarbeitung	Claude (Anthropic)	Korrektur von Grammatik und Stil einzelner Abschnitte